

LLMs in Composition: Theory, Ethics, and Implementation in the Workplace and Classroom

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Kylie Alexis Wilczynski¹ 

Abstract

Large Language Models (LLMs) have ignited discourse within the Technical and Professional Communications (TPC) community in relation to authorship and accountability. This article employs a qualitative synthesis of current and theoretical scholarship regarding authorship theory and LLMs. This analysis argues that while LLMs provide assistance to improve human-generated text, LLMs are unable to participate in authorship, as they cannot be held accountable for their outputs, participate in reciprocity, or demonstrate rhetorical awareness regarding audience and context. The analysis urges professors and professionals to consider concrete guidelines surrounding LLM usage to create transparency in the classroom and workplace.

Keywords

business writing, college writing, ethics, rhetoric, Authorship, Artificial Intelligence

For years, the online encyclopedia website, well-known as *Wikipedia*, was taboo in the writing community. Instructors forbade students from using it because of its lack of credibility and well-known accessibility to all internet users. In recent years, *Wikipedia*'s taboo has de-escalated, as editors and administrators have taken authorship of this site. While *Wikipedia* should still not be considered a “credible” source for formal research writing, the online encyclopedia provides internet users with general information about topics that work as a springboard for more detailed thoughts and ideas; *Wikipedia* helps “speed up” the writing and thinking process, as it provides

¹Bowling Green State University, USA

Corresponding Author:

Kylie Alexis Wilczynski, Bowling Green State University, 1001 E. Wooster St., Bowling Green, OH 43403, USA.

Email: kalittle19@gmail.com

quick and simple access to information and answers for users worldwide. In recent years, generative artificial intelligence has worked its way into writing taboo, replacing the formerly denounced *Wikipedia*.

Here, I wish to find an answer to a pressing question for not only writing instructors, but business professionals as well: Can large language models participate in the writing process enough to receive authorship status, or is it no more than an assistive tool, comparable to a combination of *Wikipedia* and word-processor tools? This essay explores theoretical foundations of authorship and collaboration in Technical Professional Writing in unison with current scholarship on generative Artificial Intelligence, specifically large language models (LLMs), in an attempt to suggest effective and ethical guidelines for Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) usage in Technical Professional Writing (TPW). LLMs are an assistive tool and cannot, at this moment, contribute to authorship, coauthorship, or ghost writer status because of their inability to fully demonstrate rhetorical awareness, specifically regarding audience and context, alongside their inability to reciprocate in the collaborative process (Teixeira da Silva & Tsigaris, 2023) or take accountability for their output. Lastly, to remain relevant in a postindustrial, technology-driven society, technical and professional communicators must prioritize not the speed at which their writing is created but the efficiency and ethical boundaries in which their communications are created.

Authorial Responsibility

To determine LLM's status as an author, we first must contextualize the theoretical foundations of authorship in contemporary critical theory. French philosophers Michel Foucault and Roland Barthes question the relevance of the author in producing meaning from text. Barthes, specifically, wishes to prioritize the interpretative meaning of the reader, rather than the intention of the author: "To give a text an Author is to impose a limit on that text, to furnish it with a final signified, to close the writing" (2018, p. 1271). In Barthes's essay, he suggests that the meaning of a text should be left to the interpretation of the reader, over traditional authorial meaning. While Foucault questions Barthes' disregard of the author entirely, he poses essential conclusions at the end of his seminal essay "What is an Author":

New questions will be heard:

"What are the modes of existence of this discourse?"

"Where does it come from; how is it circulated; who controls it?"

"What placements are determined for possible subjects?"

"Who can fulfill these diverse functions of the subject?"

Behind all these questions we would hear little more than the murmur of indifference:

"What matter who's speaking?" (2018, p. 1409)

Here, Foucault considers the relationship between the subject and the author, while also forcing his reader to grapple with the possibility that, after a reader perceives a

text, it becomes independent from its author. Foucault acknowledges the power and, therefore, responsibility that accompany authorship while understanding the power everyone, or subject, holds when encountering a text. Slack et al. (2004) reemphasize in their essay “Technical Communicator as Author” Foucault’s understanding of authorial responsibility: “the function of an author is to characterize the existence, circulations, and operation of certain discourses within a society” (Foucault, 2018, p. 1400). Although the individual’s intention in creating textual meaning has decreased in relevance during the 20th-21st centuries, and not all authors of documents are given the same societal prestige as authors of, say, literary fiction, an author still maintains the privilege of engaging in societal discourse; of choosing which meanings to circulate in society, and whose discourse is “worth” engaging in. Within this privilege, authors maintain the responsibility to create meanings that accurately and responsibly engage in said discourse. An author must take part in the foundations of the rhetorical situation. The author must consider rhetorical elements (context, audience, medium, and purpose) to create meaning or their desired message. While textual meaning maintains relevance, author(s) of a text, and their intended meaning, maintain relevance as well because of this engagement in societal discourse. To be an author is to choose a community and engage in its discourse.

Charlotte Thralls and Nancy Roundy Blyler expand on communal discourse in their essay, “The Social Perspective and Professional Communication.” Here, the two argue the inseparable connection between discourse and community; they claim that because communities are inherently sources of knowledge, and discourse shapes community and vice versa, “Writers produce communications based on their understanding of communal expectations” (Thralls & Blyler, 2004, pp. 127–128). Not only does authorship emphasize the privilege to choose what discourse to engage in, but authorship also implies being part of a community, as writing is a social process. Authorship entails emphasizing communal norms and certain voices, while “render[ing] transparent the contribution of others” (Thralls & Blyler, 2004, p. 162). From here, I synthesize theoretical foundations of authorship from Foucault (2018), Slack et al (2004), and Thralls and Blyler (2004), with current LLM scholarship regarding authorship, accountability, and accuracy, while expanding on the circulation of power and communal discourse. I end this section with implications of LLM authorship in the technical communication classroom and workplace, alongside potential practical and ethical complications that accompany the usage of LLM software.

LLMs Enter the Authorship Conversation

Notably, LLMs fail to meet key criteria within the scientific publishing community. In 2023, J.A. Teixeira da Silva and P. Tsigaris explored authorship as defined by the International Committee of Medical Journal Editors (ICMJE), and while LLMs could arguably meet some criteria defined by ICMJE, J. A. Teixeira da Silva and P. Tsigaris argue that LLMs fail to satisfy two key requirements of authorship: accountability and consent to publication. On page 454 of their “Human- and AI-based authorship” article, they note, “the fourth and final clause of the ICMJE states that: ‘agreement to

be accountable for all aspects of the work in ensuring that questions related to the accuracy or integrity of any part of the work are appropriately investigated and resolved.”” Authorship implies a responsibility to the subjects of a text in the production of meaning; while authors may use LLMs during the writing process, LLMs cannot be held accountable for their outputs when circulated into public discourse: only humans can choose to circulate discourse, and be held accountable if the discourse is false or misleading. In this same article, Teixeira da Silva and Tsigaris ask ChatGPT if it feels it can contribute to the authorship status enough to receive credit, and the LLM cites the same authorship guidelines from the ICMJE (2023). Even the LLM ChatGPT acknowledges the ethical implications involved in receiving authorship status and self-accountability.

Foucault’s question “Where does it come from; how is it circulated; who controls it?” becomes the most essential question when considering the implementation of LLMs into regular authorship routines, while also helping reemphasize the importance of accountability. The correlation between authorship status and the circulation of knowledge, and henceforth societal power, is a conversation echoed in many realms of academic theory. Slack et al. explore the technical communicator’s status as an author, emphasizing key ethical dilemmas that the status of authorship faces. When contextualizing authorship theory established by Barthes, Foucault, and other poststructuralist figures, the idea of authorship implies a circulation of voice and power. LLM users cannot fully examine the voices contributing to most popular LLM outputs, because of corporate ownership and nonexistent government regulations. Teixeira et al. recognize that “AI is a machine learning tool that is not an autonomous, independent cognitive unit but needs to be directed, trained, or supervised by humans to execute orders like research software” (2023, p. 454) LLMs do not independently choose to circulate voices in society; individuals provide pre-authored content so LLMs can predict successful output patterns. Juliana Kirschner also questions the hidden data corpus behind popular LLMs (2025). Not only can LLMs not be held accountable, but LLMs also do not consent to their information inputs or outputs, fully preventing them from meeting key criteria for authorship.

Theoretically, GenAI generates ideas from preexisting data; however, a lack of government regulations and corporate ownership makes it challenging for human authors to trace the source of generated content. This creates problems in both the circulation of knowledge and power and in the production of outputs. LLMs’ predictive features generate responses to human queries that are not always substantiated upon closer examination. Alex Csiszar, associate professor of history at Harvard University, recognizes that GenAI’s ability to “generate content without consistent attribution, can be seen either as a weakness or a feature depending on one’s perspective” (2024, p. 615). In the average person’s perspective, a supercomputer with access to vast datasets that can, mostly, autonomously respond to human questions without direct supervision appears limitless; however, LLMs are notorious for producing inaccurate information, which is a weakness.

While Csiszar makes valid points that the flow of knowledge has never proven as neat and concrete as academia and beyond expect it to be, this only leaves more ethical

questions involving LLMs and their ability to contribute to authorship, or the communicative process in general. Reader interpretation based on textual meaning has become increasingly important; however, as Johnson-Eilola recognizes, in a postindustrial society, knowledge attains primary value (2004). In a society where knowledge attains more value than product, the inherent power that aligns with authorship status signifies that “it does matter who’s speaking,” in a way that the author must be accountable for the information they spread. LLMs are unable to take accountability for any false or misleading information used in publication; this is especially problematic, as LLMs are known to “hallucinate,” or produce inaccurate information.

Jan Homolak, researcher at the University of Zagreb in Croatia, acknowledges AI’s limitations in “accurately conveying complex scientific concepts and information without substantial human intervention” (p. 205) in his 2023 article “Exploring the Adoption of ChatGPT in Academic Publishing: Insights and Lessons for Scientific Writing.” While LLMs are in a constant cycle of training and retraining, and constant updates coupled with new versions, LLMs have not yet outgrown their habit of producing inaccurate information. In 2025, USC Annenberg lecturer Juliana Kirschner published her article “Media Ecology and Artificial Intelligence: A Critical Perspective on Authorship and Lessons Learned From Social Media.” Even 2 years after Homolak’s article, Kirschner notes that ChatGPT specifically is “known to hallucinate, to fabricate ideas and source materials that do not exist” (p. 68). LLMs’ output inconsistencies bring into serious question their reliability as a source, let alone their reliability as an author. TPC professionals must consider output inconsistencies, coupled with LLMs’ inability to meet key authorship criteria established within the scientific publishing community, when examining LLMs’ communication capabilities.

Alex Csiszar indirectly explores Foucault’s final question, “What matter who’s speaking?” in his essay “Blurry Authorship: Originality in Science Before and After Large Language Models” (LLMs). Csiszar theorizes that our current era of LLMs is not the first era in human history in which the distribution of knowledge and authorship has been “blurred,” “gummed up,” or “malleable” (p. 616). Certainly, in any published writing, it would be impossible to truthfully cite every author who inspired the thoughts of said communication. Hence, in Barthes’s “Death of an Author,” along with similar theorists inspired by Barthes’s work, the argument becomes that the interpretation of each reader changes based on the connections made between the reader and the schema, or prior knowledge the reader already has about the topic. Each text a reader comes across shapes the way the reader interprets future texts. Slack et al. (2004) emphasize the importance of the technical writer in the circulation of power in regard to authorship status.

While the technical writer may not create content themselves, they do consider audience and context to create their desired message. Slack et al. highlight the technical writer’s participation in the articulation of voices, demonstrating the technical writer’s role in the circulation of power: “they must be able to analyze critically the ethical implications of the meanings they contribute to” (2004, p. 172). To receive credit as an author, even when that status is debated, like in the case of a technical writer, implies a responsibility to articulate voices and content that benefit society.

In response to Foucault's question, "What matter who's speaking?" Slack et al. take their answer a step further: "It is not simply *how well* we communicate that matters. *Who* we work for and *what* we communicate matters" (2004, p. 173). It is not only the singular author that necessarily matters in the production of a communication, but the organization, or community, alongside the message produced in the communication that matters; neither of these essential components of the rhetorical situation can be considered by an LLM. Both Homolak and Csiszar concur with the importance of accountability when receiving status as an author. Homolak encourages the scientific writing community to expand on its guidelines for LLM-produced communications: "Furthermore, the ownership rights and responsibility for AI-generated work, including the possibility of containing plagiarized content, are yet to be determined" (2023, p. 205). Authorship, coauthorship, and even ghost writer status imply ethical responsibility and accountability that LLMs cannot, at this moment, participate in. Ethical guidelines and current scholarship implore that it does matter who is speaking, to hold authors accountable for producing not only clear communications, but accurate communications as well. While reallocating textual interpretation from the author to the subject helps redistribute societal power, authors maintain the power to choose which communal discourses to circulate in society.

As LLMs' inability to consent and take accountability for their output has been covered, there is one additional component to authorship that should be considered in relation to LLMs: community. While LLMs possess the ability to provide perspective on a text in regard to format, organization, and grammatical strengths and weaknesses, LLMs cannot technically collaborate, which is an essential aspect of the writing process. Teixeira da Silva et al. remind us that reciprocity is a large part of the social act of writing: "Meanwhile, AI cannot be guest or gift authors as it does not engage in reciprocity, although human authors could easily treat AI as ghost authors" (2023, p. 454). LLMs mimic components of collaboration; however, they are unable to technically engage in communal discourse because they do not engage in reciprocity. While humans can benefit from LLMs, LLMs do not benefit from human inputs; because of this lack of mutual benefit, LLMs are not part of any communal discourse. Only humans who input information into LLMs can engage in community.

In the context of TPC, communities or organizations are perceived as authors, especially in the common case that multiple individuals collaborate on one text. In "Revisiting Four Conversations in Technical and Professional Writing Scholarship to Frame Conversations About Artificial Intelligence," Bill Hart-Davidson et al., all affiliated with the department of Writing and Rhetoric at Michigan State University, published in 2024, connect current conversations in TPC with LLMs; notably, the group also discusses LLMs in connection with authorship and collaboration. Hart-Davidson et al. acknowledge that LLMs can aid in the many steps that create a text, but evoke the idea that more often than not in TPC, "The Organization is the author" (p. 78). Thralls and Blyler even note that "communities are constituted by the language their members employ" (2004, p. 129). This presents significant issues involved with LLM outputs in the context of an organization; because LLMs are unable to differentiate

voice among contexts and audience (Wilson & Rose, 2025), they are unable to reciprocate, and users are unable to identify source information within LLM outputs (which will be discussed in a later section), organizations should encourage LLM use sparingly. Hart-Davidson et al. champion the sparing usage of LLMs, reminding readers that “humans will pay a price if we take process shortcuts enabled by technology” (2025, p. 79). Human users will be accountable for citing LLM outputs in their communications. Organizations should present ethical boundaries and suggestions when encouraging LLM use by their employees. Although LLMs do not meet authorship requirements, LLMs, like a word processor and other various technologies, aid in the communication process and will continue to be utilized by writers.

Classroom and Workplace Implications

Many scholars believe the expectations of LLM usage vary between the academic world and the “professional” workspace. Meghan Velez and Alex Rister, from the Department of Writing and Rhetoric at the University of Central Florida, published their article, “Beyond Academic Integrity: Navigating Institutional and Disciplinary Anxieties About AI-Assisted Authorship in Technical and Professional Communication,” in October 2025 (per Sage Journals). The pair work to critique the inconsistencies of LLM taboo in the Technical Professional Communications (TPC) classroom versus its encouraged usage in workplace settings: “67% of executives and 64% of managers ‘believe generative AI can help them communicate more effectively,’ with early adopters holding positive views of GenAI tools related to workplace productivity and the quality of their work” (p. 116). Velez and Rister specifically criticize higher education institutions for their hesitancy in implementing AI-assisted writing into the TPC classrooms; the pair claim that “academia’s narrow framing of AI as a threat to academic integrity and original authorship and its uncertainty about how faculty might productively integrate AI technologies into their courses signal a disconnect between classroom writing and the kinds of literacies and practices expected of professionals” (2025, p. 127). The TPC classroom is often a place highly criticized when perceived as not paralleling “real-world” experience. Because, of course, TPC writing courses seek to prepare students for various potential communication situations based on their future careers, professors must model their writing expectations after those of the workplace.

Velez and Rister continue to claim that “negative consequences such as worker replacement” (2025, p. 127) may deter academic institutions from learning about LLM software and teaching future TPC professionals how to utilize LLM software to their advantage. Hart-Davidson et al. even recognize that “while the use of AI writing tools may indeed be problematic in many school contexts, for people at work, it can make difficult processes easier, faster, and less expensive” (2025, p. 77). Workplace productivity is, of course, a priority to many members of organizations; however, Hart-Davidson et al. also encourage LLM users that writing is more than an output, because it involves “refinement and understanding” (2025, p. 83), which are areas LLMs fall short in.

While Velez and Rister seek to criticize higher education for considering potential negative consequences from LLM implementation, shouldn't the TPC classroom be a space where students and professors alike consider the ethical implications of unregulated technologies that may be sought to replace a vast amount of the human workforce? The lingering question remains: will LLM technologies replace TPC professionals? Winny Wilson and Heath Rose from the University of Oxford weigh in on this topic in their article, "A Genre, Scoring, and Authorship Analysis of AI-Generated and Human-Written Refusal Emails," published in March 2025. In their analysis, Wilson and Rose survey humans and LLMs to compose refusal emails for various audiences and contexts: two key components of the rhetorical situation. Wilson and Rose pose their research question: "If AI-generated texts are equally as well-written as human texts, is there still a case for teaching this genre in business written communication training?" (2025, p. 2). The two examine the email responses utilizing a sample size of human assessors, specifically, educators with experience in Business Writing, to determine consistencies and inconsistencies between LLM and human outputs when analyzing a variety of prompts that slightly alter the rhetorical situation of the refusal emails.

Wilson and Rose's study develops several integral conclusions; most notably, that while LLMs produce more consistent communications, which check boxes such as grammatical correctness, this consistency was perceived as formulaic and repetitive, demonstrating a lack of "overall rhetorical awareness as neither adjusted the writing style to fit the various contexts and audiences varied by prompt" (2025, p. 13). The authors note that study participants preferred human-produced refusal communications over LLM-produced communications: specifically, popular LLMs ChatGPT and Google Gemini. Because technical communicators are emphasized for their knowledge of writing in various rhetorical situations, and LLMs are unable to vary their outputs based on audience and context, Wilson and Rose answer their research question: yes, there is still a case for teaching refusal emails (at least) in business writing courses. The two conclude their study by claiming that while LLMs may produce better communications in some genres, like argumentative essays, written communications that require relationship building are perceived as better, because of their genuineness, when produced by humans (Wilson & Rose, 2025). While LLMs can still enhance human writing skills, humans' ability to change voices and disregard formulaic writing steps based on a communications (and organizations) context and audience is a skill currently only possessed by humans.

As the Wilson and Rose study demonstrates, human-produced written communications are, at least in some cases, preferred over LLM-generated communications. Humans respond better when they perceive communications as human-produced. While more studies need to be conducted regarding human responses to LLM-produced texts, TPC educators and business professionals have a responsibility to acknowledge that LLMs are a tool that can enhance human writing by fixing grammatical errors, providing ideas and outlines, and responding to human-produced drafts; however, LLMs are not a replacement for human-generated text, especially when the goal of a communication is to develop a personal relationship (which, in many cases, TPCs are).

Complications in Practice and Ethics

LLMs have proven to speed up and simplify the written communication process. As Velez and Rister, and some other scholars acknowledge, predictive language models' ability to produce outlines, provide immediate and explicit feedback, and even revise human-generated writing is undeniable. But, like the Ship of Theseus paradox, academic and business professionals must determine boundaries regarding LLMs. If an LLM replaces all or most of a human-generated text, is the text still authored by the human inputting queries into the LLM? If an LLM provides the idea, outline, and generates the text, who, or what, is the author of the generated text? This essay has highlighted significant problems in the circulation of power in correlation with LLM corporations, and more scholarship exists questioning the ethical implications of using popular LLMs owned by the wealthiest among us. While scholarship and LLM outputs appear to consistently agree that LLMs do not meet authorship criteria at this moment, this does not prevent authors from utilizing LLMs to produce communications, and, unfortunately, scholarship agrees that the identification of LLMs in written communications is perhaps more inconsistent than LLM outputs themselves.

Even if most scholars agree that an LLM cannot be an author, and the average scholarship seeks to persuade users of LLMs to consider the ethical implications of their communications, detecting LLM usage in technical communications boils down to the honor system. Homolak notes this ethical boundary by stating that "neither humans nor AI detection tools can reliably identify text generated by AI" (2023, p. 205). GenAI usage is difficult to prove in business and academia; not only can humans not consistently "prove" that an LLM was used in written communications, but GenAI software developed to determine LLM usage also unreliably detects human text as LLM and vice versa. Although some institutions allow the usage of LLMs with proper citations, the taboo of LLMs lingers, which may leave communicators dishonest about their use. While AI detection tools and human perception are not entirely dependable, Wilson and Rose's study demonstrates that humans can more successfully identify human-generated text. Wilson and Rose note that while the participants in their study only accurately identified texts generated by LLMs 68.1% of the time, participants were able to identify human-produced texts 86.1% of the time (2025, p. 11).

The inconsistency of identifying GenAI and LLMs causes stress and paranoia among educators, publishers, business professionals, and even the average content consumer. Kirschner acknowledges this uncertainty in informal spaces like social media: "Sometimes it can even be unclear if a social media post was authored by a human or by a bot. In this way, authorship becomes muddled with the use of bots repeating whatever programming that was designed for them" (2025, p. 70). With missing government regulations prohibiting advertisers and social media platforms from allowing bot accounts to generate content, the future looks questionable. Hart-Davidson et al. note that "in the near future, GenAI capability will be more embedded, more integrated into other systems and devices, making it harder to detect, understand, scrutinize, and critique." (2025, p. 85) Circulating social media posts already demonstrate LLMs' ability to improve their mimicry of human text in both its written and

multimodal outputs (like images and videos). Not only do TPC professionals have to consider placing guidelines around LLM usage, but so does the world.

Conclusion

Again, while authorship theory and guidelines do not permit LLMs' authorship status, LLMs are universally accessible to users and difficult to "prove" in written communications. Placing a taboo on LLMs will not prevent users from using their outputs in their writing; it will only make users dishonest about their LLM usage. To create a culture of honesty and clarity in the AI age, members of organizations in the workplace and classroom alike need to communicate clear, explicit boundaries about what LLM outputs can and cannot be used for in communications, and also, how and when to cite LLM usage.

Lastly, TPC professionals and students should accept and encourage that LLM usage will look different in the classroom than in a non-academic context. Writing is not only a social process, but also a learning process. To maintain relevance in a postindustrial technological society, we should not discourage students from understanding each part of the communication process, no matter how time-consuming, so that, as LLMs continue to develop, students can demonstrate full awareness of effective and ineffective communication techniques and rhetorical awareness in their nonacademic careers.

ORCID iD

Kylie Alexis Wilczynski  <https://orcid.org/0009-0009-7088-3383>

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Author Biography

Kylie Alexis Wilczynski is a graduate student in the Professional Writing and Rhetoric program at Bowling Green State University. She teaches English at a public high school. Her research interests include improving young adult literacy through composition and multimodal pedagogies, and AI's impact and implementation in composition.

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